Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Dickinson's "[A narrow fellow in the grass]" and Roethke's "Snake"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of these poems include

contrast,
couplet,
diction,
free verse,
imagery,
metaphor,
meter,
onomatopoeia,
optimism,
personification,
simile,
style,
sympathy/empathy,
theme, and
tone.

The contestant is asked to discuss the appreciation of the natural world that is evident in each of the persona's reactions to meeting a snake on his own turf. The discussion might well be a comparison, though it might focus solely on contrasting elements, especially style and tone. He or she might find the quality of the language, which is visual (and suggestive of auditory) in Dickinson's present-tense encounter and characteristically sensuous in Roethke's memory of the encounter, a point of focus.

Both Dickinson and Roethke find pleasure in observing a snake; however, Dickinson spends a bit more time with the snake itself; Roethke moves quickly toward the possibility of identifying himself in terms of the snake.

The young writer might point to the distance established and maintained in the Dickinson observation, a distance that is empathetically closed in the Roethke observation-become-identification.